

BELLOMO LEADERSHIP

The Courage Economy

The Skeptic's Appendix

Every serious objection to the Lie Economy Calculator and our honest answers

A framework about truth-telling should tell the truth about itself.

WHY THIS DOCUMENT EXISTS

Read This Before You Trust Our Numbers

Most ROI calculators hope you won't look too closely. This one asks you to. The Courage Economy is a framework about making truth cheaper than comfort so it would be an odd hypocrisy to ship a calculator that hides its assumptions and hopes for the best.

Below are the six strongest objections a skeptical executive should raise about this tool. We wrote them as sharply as we could. Sharper, probably, than most prospects would say out loud. For each one we include our honest answer, including the places where the objection is simply right.

One definition before we start. This calculator is directional, not actuarial. An actuarial model prices your specific risk from your specific data and stakes money on being right. A directional model tells you the order of magnitude of a cost you are currently treating as zero, so you can decide whether it deserves attention. We claim the second, never the first. Every number this tool produces is an argument, not an audit.

The purpose of this calculator is not to be believed. It is to be argued with. The moment you say "that 20% figure is too high for us, it's more like 10%," you are no longer debating whether your organization has a Lie Economy. You are negotiating its size. Turn every dial down to your most conservative estimate. The number that remains is yours, not ours and it is still not zero.

OBJECTION 1

1

"You made these numbers up."

"The 20% fake-work rate, the 0.65 overlap factor, the 1.5 exponent - these are chosen parameters wearing research citations as a costume. The research proves these costs exist. It does not authorize your magnitudes."

Our honest answer

Partially guilty, and we'll be precise about which part. The cost categories are established by research: suppressed voice, fake work, preventable attrition, and decision failure are documented, studied, quantified phenomena. Nobody serious disputes that they exist or that they are expensive.

The specific parameters, 20%, 0.65, the 1.5 exponent, the 30% amplifier, are modeling choices. They are anchored to published medians where medians exist, chosen conservatively where they don't, and disclosed completely in the methodology document. They are not derived from a controlled study of Courage Scores against financial outcomes, because no such study exists yet. We would love to run one.

This is exactly how every early-stage model in every field works, including the ones your company already uses. Your market-sizing models, your risk matrices, your engagement survey benchmarks: all chosen parameters, anchored to research, refined by contact with reality. The difference is that we're telling you.

VERDICT: The objection is right about precision and wrong about usefulness. If our parameters are off by half, your Lie Economy is still a seven-figure line item you currently budget at zero.

OBJECTION 2

2

"This is unfalsifiable."

"If the company performs well, the Lie Economy is capping its potential. If it performs badly, the Lie Economy is the cause. If my score is high, it's inflated. There is no result your framework can't absorb - and a theory that explains everything predicts nothing."

Our honest answer

This is the best objection in the document, and it deserves the most careful answer: the calculator is not the evidence. It is the hypothesis. The evidence is observable, cheap, and does not require believing us:

- Count the decisions your leadership team reversed in the last ninety days and ask how many of the reversals were predicted by someone who didn't say so in the room.
- Count the meetings this month that produced no decision.
- Re-read the exit interviews from your last five regretted departures and ask whether you believe them.
- Ask when bad news last reached you before it was unfixable - and when it didn't.
- Run a pre-mortem on your most important current initiative and watch what surfaces that was previously unsaid.

Every one of these is a falsifiable, local test. If your reversals were all genuinely unforeseeable, your meetings decisive, your exit interviews candid, and your bad news fast, the model is wrong about you, and we will say so. The calculator's job is to make those checks feel worth an afternoon.

On the Candor Adjustment: fair hit. A correction that only moves scores downward can function as a device for dismissing disconfirming data, which is the same move horoscopes make. That's why it is optional, labeled, and off by default. It is there to let you stress-test your own self-assessment, not to let us escape yours.

VERDICT: Right about the framing risk; wrong that there's nothing to test. The framework stakes its credibility on observable operational facts, reversal rates, decision velocity, news latency, not on its own diagnostic.

OBJECTION 3

3

"Every vendor has one of these."

"Gallup has a disengagement calculator. Slack had a collaboration-cost calculator. The wellness vendor has a stress calculator. If I believed all of them, my company lost 400% of payroll last year. These are marketing artifacts, not information."

Our honest answer

Correct and the 400% problem is real. Every vendor's calculator attributes overlapping costs to its own specialty and summing them produces nonsense. Three things distinguish this one, and you can verify each in the methodology document:

- It deduplicates against itself. Our three labor-based categories are explicitly discounted ($\times 0.65$) because they tax the same hours. We did to our own numbers what the vendor ecosystem refuses to do to each other's.
- It publishes ranges, not points. A tool that says "\$5.83M" is performing precision it doesn't have. Ours says "\$2.2M–\$4.6M" because that's what directional honesty looks like.
- It attacks itself in writing. You are reading the attack right now. Find us another vendor calculator that ships with a document titled "The Skeptic's Appendix."

And yes - this calculator is also a marketing artifact. It exists so that a conversation starts. Both things are true, and pretending otherwise would be a comfortable lie in a product about comfortable lies.

VERDICT: Right about the genre; the answer is that we broke the genre's rules on purpose. Judge the tool by whether its self-imposed discounts and disclosures hold up. They're all published.

OBJECTION 4

4

"Where's the counterfactual?"

"Show me the company that did your program and captured the \$3.4M. Not a testimonial, a before-and-after with a control. And your recovery cost escalating 15% a year is just a countdown timer in a sales deck."

Our honest answer

We don't have a controlled study. Culture consulting as an industry has never produced a true controlled counterfactual, because no board will randomize its leadership behavior for science. Anyone in this field who claims experimental proof is lying to you, which would be a strange way to begin a courage engagement.

What exists instead is convergent evidence from fields that couldn't afford silence: aviation's Crew Resource Management, which measurably reduced accidents by making dissent mandatory; hospital safety-reporting cultures with measurably lower error mortality; the documented postmortems of Boeing, Volkswagen, Theranos, and Wells Fargo, where the cost of suppressed truth ran to billions and the silence is a matter of public record. The mechanism is not speculative. Only its price at your company is.

On the 15% recovery escalation: the specific rate is a modeling choice and we concede it plainly. The direction is not. Adverse selection is real. Truth-tellers exit lie economies first, and each year the people who would have helped you change are more likely to be gone. If you think 15% is wrong, pick your own rate. Any positive number still means the same thing: later is more expensive than now.

VERDICT: Right that no controlled proof exists, for us or anyone in this industry. The mechanism is documented across safety-critical fields; the tool prices it directionally. Treat the output as a reason to run your own before-and-after, and we'll help you instrument it.

OBJECTION 5

5

"You're insulting me in my own house."

"Your diagnostic tells my leadership team that the organization we built runs on lies. Your own framework predicts what happens next: we perform polite interest and never call you back."

Our honest answer

This objection is completely correct, and we've stopped fighting it. The framework predicts its own rejection by leaders who are personally invested in the culture as it stands. Comfort defeating truth is the entire thesis, and it applies to the sales meeting too.

So, this tool is not really for the executive who built the house. It is for the executive who just moved in. The leader six months into a role, standing in a culture they didn't create, who can smell that something is wrong and needs two things. A language for it and a number for it. For that person, the diagnosis isn't an insult. It's a relief. It has a name, it has a price, and it isn't their fault. Yet.

If you did build the house and you're still reading: that is, precisely, the courage the framework is about, and the diagnostic will treat you accordingly. The Lie Economy is not a moral failure of leaders. It is the rational equilibrium of organizations that accidentally price truth higher than comfort. You didn't choose it. You can, however, be the one who reprices it.

VERDICT: Fully conceded - and repurposed. The calculator's primary audience is the inheritor, not the architect. Architects who engage anyway are self-selecting for exactly the trait the work requires.

OBJECTION 6

6

"If this were real, I'd already see it."

"If silence cost 27% of payroll, companies that fixed it would visibly crush their competitors, and private equity would be arbitraging low-courage companies. Where's the market signal?"

Our honest answer

The market signal exists, it's just never labeled courage. When a turnaround operator takes over and value jumps, the mechanics are usually these mechanics: decisions speed up, information reaches the top unfiltered, fake work gets killed, the right people stop leaving. PE firms do arbitrage this. They call it "operational improvement" and "management upgrade." The industry monetizes the Lie Economy every day without ever naming it.

Why doesn't the label surface? Because culture is a lagging, illegible variable that markets price only through its symptoms like margins, attrition, execution speed. By the time silence shows up in a quarterly number, it has been operating for years, and the earnings call attributes it to "headwinds." Illegibility is not absence. It's the reason a diagnostic has value: it makes a real cost legible before the market prices it for you.

VERDICT: The arbitrage already happens under other names. This framework doesn't claim to have discovered the phenomenon - it claims to have named it early enough for you to act before your buyer does.

How to Use This Calculator Honestly

- Turn every dial to your most conservative estimate. Own the number that remains.
- Treat the output as a floor, not a forecast. Self-scored diagnostics in low-candor cultures inflate scores, which means they understate costs.
- Don't act on our number. Act on your own ninety-day evidence: reversals, indecisive meetings, exit-interview candor, bad-news latency.
- If your conservative number is still uncomfortable, the discomfort is the finding.

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